**Lowering of Voting Age** The 61st Constitutional Amendment Act of 1988 reduced the voting age from 21 years to 18 years for the Lok Sabha as well as the assembly elections. This was done in order to provide to the unrepresented youth of the country an opportunity to express their feelings and help them become a part of political process.

**Deputation to Election Commission** In 1989[2], a provision was made that the officers and the staff engaged in preparation, revision and correction of electoral rolls for elections are deemed to be on deputation to the Election Commission for the period of such employment. These personnel, during that period, would be under the control, superintendence and discipline of the Election Commission.

**Increase in Number of Proposers** In 1989[3], the number of electors who are required to sign as proposers in nomination papers for elections to the Rajya Sabha and state legislative council has been increased to 10 per cent of the electors of the constituency or ten such electors, whichever is less. This was done in order to prevent non-serious candidates from contesting frivolously.

**Electronic Voting Machines** In 1989[4], a provision was made to facilitate the use of Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs) in elections. The EVMs were used for the first time in 1998 on experimental basis in selected constituencies in the elections to the Assemblies of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Delhi. The EVMs were used for the first time in the general elections (entire state) to the Assembly of Goa in 1999.

**Booth Capturing** In 1989[5], a provision was made for adjournment of poll or countermanding of elections in case of booth capturing. Booth capturing includes: (i) seizure of a polling station and making polling authorities surrender ballot papers or voting machines (ii) taking possession of polling station and allowing only one's own supporters to exercise their franchise (iii) threatening and preventing any elector from going to polling station and (iv) seizure of the place being used for counting of votes.

Elector's Photo Identity Card (EPIC) The use of electors' photo identity cards by the Election Commission is surely making the electoral process simple, smoother and quicker. A decision was taken by the Election Commission in 1993 to issue photo identity cards to electors throughout the country to check bogus voting and impersonation of electors at elections. The electoral roll is the basis for issue of EPICs to the registered electors[6].

**ELECTORAL REFORMS OF 1996**

In 1990, the National Front Government headed by V.P. Singh appointed a committee on electoral reforms under the chairmanship of Dinesh Goswami, the then Law Minister. The Committee was asked to study the electoral system in detail and suggest measures for remedying the drawbacks within it. The Committee, in its report submitted in 1990 itself, made a number of proposals on electoral reforms. Some of these recommendations were implemented in 1996[7]. These are explained here.

**Listing of Names of Candidates** The candidates contesting elections are to be classified into three categories for the purpose of listing of their names. They are

1. Candidates of recognised political parties
2. Candidates of registered-unrecognised political parties
3. Other (independent) candidates